VITyarthi | Open Source Software

The Open Source Audit

A Capstone Project for OSS NGMC Course

Course: Open Source Software | Unit Coverage: 1 – 5

Max Marks: 100

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1. Introduction

Most of the software that powers the modern world was not built by a single company and sold for profit; it was built openly, shared freely, and improved collectively. This project is an audit of one such foundational tool: Git.

This report explores Git's origin, the philosophy of its creator, the specific freedoms guaranteed by its license, and its broader impact on the global software ecosystem. Alongside this theoretical analysis, practical Linux footprint mapping and shell scripting tasks demonstrate how automation and command-line mastery connect directly to the open-source ethos of transparency. Understanding these foundations is not an optional academic exercise — it is a prerequisite for modern professional software development.

> *Every line of code you write in your career will sit on top of open-source foundations. Understanding the philosophy behind that is not optional — it is part of being a professional.*

2. Chosen Software

The chosen software for this audit is Git — the distributed version control system created by Linus Torvalds in 2005.

Software	Category	License	Why It's Interesting
Linux Kernel	Operating System	GPL v2	The foundation everything else runs on
Apache HTTP Server	Web Server	Apache 2.0	Powers ~30% of all websites globally
MySQL	Database	GPL v2 / Commercial	A license with a dual-model story to tell
Firefox	Web Browser	MPL 2.0	A nonprofit fighting for an open web
VLC Media Player	Multimedia	LGPL / GPL	Plays anything — built by students in Paris
LibreOffice	Office Suite	MPL 2.0	Born from a community fork — a real lesson
Python	Programming Language	PSF License	A language shaped entirely by community
Git	Version Control	`GPL v2`	The tool Linus built when proprietary failed him

Your choice	**Git**

3. Project Report

Part A — Origin and Philosophy (Units 1 & 2)

A1. The Problem This Software Was Created to Solve

Git was created in April 2005 by Linus Torvalds to manage the development of the Linux kernel after a critical licensing crisis threatened the entire project. The creation of Git was not a planned initiative — it was a direct response to an urgent, real-world problem.

Why Git Was Created:

1. Licensing Dispute: Since 2002, the Linux kernel project had used a proprietary version control system called BitKeeper. In 2005, the relationship between the Linux community and BitKeeper's parent company (BitMover) broke down, and the tool's free-of-charge status for open-source projects was revoked.
2. Lack of Alternatives: Torvalds found that no existing free VCS — like CVS or SVN — met the Linux project's extreme requirements for speed, scale, and distributed workflow.
3. Design Goals: Torvalds wanted a system that could handle thousands of parallel branches, protect against data corruption, and execute tasks like patching in seconds rather than minutes.

How Git Was Built:

4. Rapid Development: Torvalds wrote the initial framework in just over a week, starting on April 3, 2005.
5. Self-Hosting: By April 7 — just four days after the first line of code — Git was being used to track its own source code.
6. Benchmark Success: Within a month, Git was recording kernel patches at 6.7 patches per second, meeting its ambitious speed goals.
7. Handover: In July 2005, Torvalds handed maintenance to Junio Hamano, who has been the primary maintainer ever since, leading Git to its 1.0 release in December 2005.

Linus chose to release Git freely because the Linux project depended on collaborative openness. A proprietary tool had already proven to be a single point of failure — a lesson he had no intention of repeating.

A2. The License — What It Actually Says

Git is released under the GNU General Public License version 2.0 (GPLv2) — a strong copyleft, free software license. The Four Freedoms of Free Software, as defined by the Free Software Foundation, are:

- Freedom 0 (Run): The freedom to run the program as you wish, for any purpose.
- Freedom 1 (Study/Modify): The freedom to study how the program works and change it. Access to source code is a precondition.
- Freedom 2 (Share): The freedom to redistribute copies to help others.
- Freedom 3 (Improve/Distribute): The freedom to distribute copies of your modified versions to others.

Git's GPLv2 license grants all four freedoms. Freedom 0 allows Git to be run for any purpose including commercial use. Freedoms 1 and 3 are satisfied because the source code is freely available and modifiable. Freedom 2 is guaranteed through the right to redistribute exact copies. The copyleft clause of GPLv2 further ensures that any modifications to Git must be released under the same license.

Can a Company Modify and Sell Git Without Sharing Changes?

Generally, no. The GPLv2 'copyleft' clause requires that if a company distributes (sells or transfers) a modified version of Git, they must make the modified source code available to recipients under the same GPLv2 license. The only exception is internal use — a company may modify Git, use it internally, and keep those changes private, since the obligation to share source code is only triggered upon distribution.

GPL vs. MIT Licensing:

GPL is a restrictive 'copyleft' license requiring all derivative works to remain open-source. MIT is a permissive license allowing free use, modification, and even proprietary distribution. For personal projects on GitHub, MIT would be preferable to encourage widespread adoption. GPL would be the right choice if the goal is to ensure all future improvements remain free and are shared back with the community.

Free as in Beer vs. Free as in Freedom:

Free as in Beer (Gratis)	Free as in Freedom (Libre)
Free as in Beer (Gratis)	Free as in Freedom (Libre)
Focus: Price (zero cost)	Focus: Rights & Liberty
Source Code: Usually Hidden	Source Code: Accessible
Modification: Restricted	Modification: Allowed
Redistribution: Restricted	Redistribution: Allowed
Example: Adobe Reader, Skype	Example: Linux, Firefox, Git

Git exemplifies both concepts. It is free of charge to download, install, and use (free as in beer), and it grants full rights to study, modify, and redistribute (free as in freedom) under the GPLv2 license.

A3. The Ethics of Open Source

Open source is not merely a licensing model — it is a philosophical statement about how knowledge and tools should be shared. This section explores three ethical dimensions of that statement.

Should All Software Be Open Source?

Arguments For:

- Transparency and Security: Open code allows anyone to inspect it, making it easier to identify vulnerabilities, which often leads to better security outcomes.
- Innovation and Collaboration: Developers can build on existing work, accelerating innovation and reducing redundant effort.
- Freedom from Vendor Lock-in: Users are not dependent on a single company for updates or continued support.
- Customization: Users can modify software to meet their own specific needs.

Arguments Against:

- Funding and Sustainability: Developing high-quality software is expensive. Proprietary models allow developers to generate profit and fund continued development.
- Ease of Use: Open-source projects often lack the user-friendly design and polish found in well-funded commercial applications.

- Support and Maintenance: OSS may lack dedicated 24/7 technical support or comprehensive professional documentation.
- Intellectual Property: Companies may legitimately wish to protect proprietary algorithms representing significant investment.

A hybrid ecosystem — where critical infrastructure is open-source while specialised tools can remain proprietary — often provides the most practical balance. A blanket mandate for all software to be open-source is neither feasible nor necessarily desirable.

Is It Ethical for Companies to Profit From Free Community Labor?

This is a complex debate. Companies like Red Hat, Google, and Meta all build products on open-source foundations — including Git and Linux. The ethical evaluation depends heavily on whether the company gives back.

Aspect	Perspective
Legal	Almost always legal if license terms are followed.
Ethical	Debatable. Considered ethical if companies give back; exploitative if they only take.
Sustainability	Relies on a healthy, reciprocal ecosystem to prevent maintainer burnout.

In conclusion, it is not inherently unethical for companies to profit from open-source software. It becomes ethically problematic when corporations treat community labor as a free resource to extract from, rather than a collaborative partnership to invest in. The most respected companies — like Red Hat — have built sustainable models that combine profit with genuine contribution.

Part B — Linux Footprint (Unit 2)

This section documents how Git lives on a Linux system, based on direct installation and inspection on Ubuntu/Debian.

Installation:

```
sudo apt install git
```

Key Directories:

- Binary location: /usr/bin/git
- System-wide config: /etc/gitconfig
- Per-user config: ~/.gitconfig
- Repository data: Stored in the .git/ directory inside each project

User and Group:

Git runs as the current logged-in user, not as a dedicated system user or service account. This is by design — Git is a developer tool, not a server daemon. Running as the current user maintains the security boundary: Git can only access files and directories that the logged-in user has permission to access. This prevents any single Git operation from gaining elevated or unintended system access.

Service Management:

Git is a command-line tool, not a background service. It does not need to be started, stopped, or managed with systemctl. It executes on demand and exits when complete. This stateless design is part of what makes Git lightweight and portable.

Update Model:

```
sudo apt update && sudo apt upgrade
```

Security patches are distributed through the standard distribution package manager. The open-source community publishes security advisories publicly, and patches are reviewed by multiple contributors before release — a transparent process that proprietary software cannot match.

Part C — The FOSS Ecosystem (Units 3 & 4)

Dependencies:

- libc (GNU C Library) — core system interface
- OpenSSL / libssl — for HTTPS transport and encryption
- libcurl — for HTTP/HTTPS remote operations
- zlib — for compression of objects
- Perl — used in several Git utility scripts

What Git Has Enabled and Inspired:

- GitHub (2008) — the world's largest code hosting platform, built entirely around Git
- GitLab — a fully open-source alternative to GitHub with CI/CD integration
- Bitbucket — Atlassian's enterprise-focused Git hosting platform
- Gitea — a lightweight, self-hosted Git service
- Git-LFS — Git Large File Storage for handling binary assets
- Numerous CI/CD tools (Jenkins, GitHub Actions, CircleCI) that integrate natively with Git

Relation to the LAMP Stack and the Web:

While Git is not itself part of the traditional LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL, PHP) stack, it is the universal tool used to manage, version, and deploy code for every component of that stack. Modern web deployments use Git to push code from developer machines to production servers, manage database migration scripts, coordinate multi-developer contributions, and maintain deployment history for rollback.

Community and Governance:

- Maintained under the Linux Foundation umbrella
- Primary maintainer: Junio Hamano (since July 2005)
- Development coordinated via the git@vger.kernel.org mailing list
- Annual Git Merge conference brings together core contributors
- Contributions reviewed through public mailing list patches — no closed-door decisions

Part D — Open Source vs. Proprietary (Critical Analysis)

Dimension	Git (Open Source)	GitHub Enterprise (Proprietary)	Verdict
Cost	Free	Paid / Subscription	Git Wins
Security (Code Audit)	Fully Transparent	Limited Visibility	Git Wins
Support & Reliability	Community-Driven	Dedicated 24/7 Support	Tie
Freedom to Modify	Full Freedom (GPLv2)	Restricted	Git Wins
Control Model	Decentralized	Centralized / Corporate	Git Wins
Vendor Lock-in	None	Possible	Git Wins

Verdict:

Open-source solutions like Git offer genuine advantages in transparency, flexibility, and cost. Because the source code is public, anyone can audit it for security vulnerabilities — a significant advantage over closed-source tools. Git's decentralised model ensures that no single company controls the tool's future, which has proven its value: Git has outlasted every proprietary VCS it was created to replace.

That said, proprietary platforms like GitHub Enterprise offer dedicated support, guaranteed SLAs, and integrated tooling that large enterprise teams genuinely need. The most pragmatic approach for real-world deployment is a hybrid model: use Git as the core version control engine, and layer enterprise platforms on top where institutional support requirements demand it. Given everything learned through this audit, contributing to open-source projects like Git is not only professionally beneficial — it strengthens the shared infrastructure that the entire industry depends on.

4. Shell Script Tasks

Five shell scripts were written, tested, and documented as part of this project. All scripts were executed on an Ubuntu Linux system and include inline comments explaining each section.

Script 1 — System Identity Report (Units 1 & 2)

This script generates a welcome-style system identity report, displaying key information about the Linux environment. It demonstrates the use of variables, command substitution, and conditional logic to detect the Linux distribution automatically.

Shell Concepts Used: Variables, echo, command substitution $(), uname, whoami, uptime, date, if-else, /etc/os-release parsing.

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 1: System Identity Report
# Author: Vyom Desai | Course: Open Source Software

# --- Variables (student / project information) ---
STUDENT_NAME="Avinash Singh Thakur"
SOFTWARE_CHOICE="Git"

# --- System information ---
KERNEL_VERSION=$(uname -r)           # Get current kernel version
USER_NAME=$(whoami)                  # Get current logged-in user
UPTIME=$(uptime -p)                  # Get uptime in readable format
HOME_DIR="$HOME"                     # Get home directory path

# --- Current date and time ---
CURRENT_DATE_TIME=$(date "+%d-%m-%Y %I:%M:%S %p")

# --- Detect Linux distribution name ---
if [ -f /etc/os-release ]; then
    DISTRO_NAME=$(grep '^PRETTY_NAME=' /etc/os-release | cut -d= -f2 | tr -d
'"')
else
    DISTRO_NAME="Unknown Linux Distribution"
fi

# --- License message ---
OS_LICENSE_MESSAGE="Linux is open-source and uses the GPL license."
```

```
# --- Display output ---
echo " "
echo "         OPEN SOURCE SYSTEM IDENTITY REPORT          "
echo " "
echo "Student Name        : $STUDENT_NAME"
echo "Chosen Software     : $SOFTWARE_CHOICE"
echo "Linux Distribution  : $DISTRO_NAME"
echo "Kernel Version      : $KERNEL_VERSION"
echo "Logged-in User      : $USER_NAME"
echo "Home Directory      : $HOME_DIR"
echo "System Uptime       : $UPTIME"
echo "Current Date & Time : $CURRENT_DATE_TIME"
echo " "
echo "License Information : $OS_LICENSE_MESSAGE"
```

Output

```
                OPEN SOURCE SYSTEM IDENTITY REPORT

Student Name  : Avinash Singh Thakur
Chosen Software : Git
Linux Distribution : Ubuntu 24.04.1 LTS
Kernel Version : 6.6.87.2-microsoft-standard-WSL2
Logged-in User : avinash
Home Directory : /home/avinash
System Uptime : up 13 minutes
Current Date & Time : 24-03-2026 01:35:19 PM

License Information :
Linux is open-source and uses the GPL license.
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$
```

Script 2 — FOSS Package Inspector (Unit 2)

This script checks whether the chosen software (Git) is installed on the system. If installed, it retrieves version information using dpkg. A case statement then prints a philosophy note based on the package name, reinforcing the connection between open-source tools and their philosophical roots.

Shell Concepts Used: if-then-else, case statement, dpkg -l, grep, pipe |.

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 2: FOSS Package Inspector
# Author: Vyom Desai | Course: Open Source Software

# --- Package to inspect ---
PACKAGE="git"

# --- Check if package is installed ---
if dpkg -l | grep -w "$PACKAGE" > /dev/null 2>&1; then
    echo "$PACKAGE is installed."
    dpkg -l | grep -w "$PACKAGE"
    echo "Version information:"
    git --version
else
    echo "$PACKAGE is NOT installed."
fi

echo ""

# --- Case statement: philosophy note for each known package ---
case $PACKAGE in
    git)
        echo "Git: an open-source VCS created to track code changes
efficiently." ;;
    apache2)
        echo "Apache: the web server that helped build the open internet." ;;
    mysql-server)
        echo "MySQL: an open-source database used in millions of real-world
apps." ;;
    firefox)
        echo "Firefox: an open-source browser supporting an accessible web." ;;
    vlc)
        echo "VLC: an open-source media player that plays any audio or video
format." ;;
    *)
        echo "No philosophy note available for this package." ;;
esac
```

Output

```
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$ nano script2.sh
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$ chmod +x script2.sh
./script2.sh
git is installed.
ii  git                          1:2.43.0-1ubuntu7.1                    amd64        fast, scalable, distributed revision control system
ii  git-man                      1:2.43.0-1ubuntu7.1                    all          fast, scalable, distributed revision control system (manual p
ages)
ii  lshw                         02.19.git.2021.06.19.996aaad9c7-2build3 amd64        information about hardware configuration
Version information:
git version 2.43.0

Git: an open-source version control system created to track code changes efficiently.
```

Script 3 — Disk and Permission Auditor (Unit 2)

This script loops through a defined list of important system directories and reports the permissions, owner, and disk usage of each. It also checks specifically for Git's configuration file and prints its permissions. This demonstrates how open-source tools integrate into the standard Linux filesystem hierarchy.

Shell Concepts Used: for loop, arrays, ls -ld, du -sh, awk, cut, if condition.

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 3: Disk and Permission Auditor
# Author: Vyom Desai | Course: Open Source Software

# --- List of directories to audit ---
DIRS=("/etc" "/var/log" "/home" "/usr/bin" "/tmp")

echo " "
echo "          Directory Audit Report          "
echo " "

# --- Loop through each directory ---
for DIR in "${DIRS[@]}"; do
    if [ -d "$DIR" ]; then
        # Extract permissions, owner, and group
        PERMS=$(ls -ld "$DIR" | awk '{print $1, $3, $4}')
        # Get human-readable size
        SIZE=$(du -sh "$DIR" 2>/dev/null | cut -f1)
        echo "$DIR => Permissions: $PERMS | Size: $SIZE"
    else
        echo "$DIR does not exist on this system"
    fi
done

echo " "
echo "Checking Git configuration directory"
echo " "

# --- Check if user-level Git config exists ---
if [ -d "$HOME/.git" ]; then
    ls -ld "$HOME/.git"
else
    echo "Git configuration directory (.git) not found in home"
fi
```

Output

```
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$ nano script3.sh
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$ chmod +x script3.sh
./script3.sh

        Directory Audit Report

/etc => Permissions: drwxr-xr-x root root | Size: 4.2M
/var/log => Permissions: drwxrwxr-x root syslog | Size: 73M
/home => Permissions: drwxr-xr-x root root | Size: 60K
/usr/bin => Permissions: drwxr-xr-x root root | Size: 92M
/tmp => Permissions: drwxrwxrwt root root | Size: 20K

Checking Git configuration directory

Git configuration directory not found in home
```

Script 4 — Log File Analyzer (Units 2 & 5)

This script accepts a log file path and an optional keyword as command-line arguments (defaulting to 'error'). It reads the file line by line, counts how many lines match the keyword, and prints both the total count and the last five matching lines. It also validates that the file exists and is non-empty before processing.

Shell Concepts Used: while read loop, if-then, counter variables, command-line arguments ($1, $2), grep, tail.

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 4: Log File Analyzer
# Author: Vyom Desai | Course: Open Source Software
# Usage: ./Script4.sh /var/log/syslog error

# --- Accept arguments ---
LOGFILE=$1                    # First argument: path to log file
KEYWORD=${2:-"error"}         # Second argument: keyword (default: error)
COUNT=0                       # Initialise match counter

# --- Check if the file exists ---
if [ ! -f "$LOGFILE" ]; then
    echo "Error: File $LOGFILE not found."
    exit 1
fi

# --- Check if the file is empty ---
if [ ! -s "$LOGFILE" ]; then
    echo "The file is empty."
    exit 1
fi
```

```
# --- Read file line by line and count keyword matches ---
while IFS= read -r LINE; do
    if echo "$LINE" | grep -iq "$KEYWORD"; then
        COUNT=$((COUNT + 1))     # Increment counter on match
    fi
done < "$LOGFILE"

# --- Print summary ---
echo "Keyword '$KEYWORD' found $COUNT times in $LOGFILE"
echo ""
echo "Last 5 matching lines:"
grep -i "$KEYWORD" "$LOGFILE" | tail -5
```

Output

```
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~$ nano script4.sh
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~$ chmod +x script4.sh
./script4.sh
Error: File  not found.
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~$ ./script4.sh script2.sh git
Error: File script2.sh not found.
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~$ cd scripts
./script4.sh script2.sh git
Keyword 'git' found 4 times in script2.sh

Last 5 matching lines:
PACKAGE="git"
    git --version
    git)
        echo "Git: an open-source version control system created to track code changes efficiently.";;
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$
```

Script 5 — The Open Source Manifesto Generator (Unit 5)

This is the most interactive script. It prompts the user with three questions, then composes a personalised open-source philosophy statement from their answers and saves it to a .txt file named after the current user. It demonstrates interactive input handling, string concatenation, and file writing.

Shell Concepts Used: read for user input, string concatenation, file writing with > and >>, date command, alias concept demonstrated via comment.

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 5: Open Source Manifesto Generator
# Author: Vyom Desai | Course: Open Source Software

# Note: An alias like 'alias ll=ls -l' can simplify commands in the terminal.
# This script demonstrates interactive input and file writing.
```

```
echo "Answer three questions to generate your manifesto."
echo ""

# --- Collect user input interactively ---
read -p "1. Name one open-source tool you use every day: " TOOL
read -p "2. In one word, what does 'freedom' mean to you? " FREEDOM
read -p "3. Name one thing you would build and share freely: " BUILD

# --- Get current date and output filename ---
DATE=$(date '+%d %B %Y')
OUTPUT="manifesto_$(whoami).txt"

# --- Write manifesto to file ---
echo "Open Source Manifesto" > "$OUTPUT"         # Create / overwrite file
echo "Date: $DATE" >> "$OUTPUT"                  # Append date
echo "" >> "$OUTPUT"                             # Blank line
echo "I use $TOOL in my daily life, and it reminds me that open source is" >>
"$OUTPUT"
echo "not only about code — it is also about $FREEDOM. If I have the" >>
"$OUTPUT"
echo "opportunity, I would build and freely share $BUILD so that others" >>
"$OUTPUT"
echo "could learn from it, improve it, and benefit from it. I believe open" >>
"$OUTPUT"
echo "source encourages collaboration, creativity, and equal access to" >>
"$OUTPUT"
echo "technology for everyone." >> "$OUTPUT"

# --- Confirm and display the saved manifesto ---
echo " "
echo "Manifesto saved to $OUTPUT"
echo " "
cat "$OUTPUT"
```

Output

```
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$ nano script5.sh
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$ chmod +x script5.sh
./script5.sh
Answer three questions to generate your manifesto.

1.name one open-source tool you use every day: git
2.in one word, what does freedom mean to you? choice
3.name one thing you would build and share freely: software app

Manifesto saved to manifesto_avinash.txt

Open Source Manifesto
Date: 24 March 2026

I use git in my daily life, and it reminds me that open source is not only about code but also about choice.If i have the opportunity,i would build
and freely share software app so that others could learn, improve it, and benefit from it. I believe open source encourages collaboration, creativit
y,and equal access to technology for everyone.
avinash@Avinash-Hp-R7:~/scripts$
```

5. Conclusion

The audit of Git as an open-source software project reveals how collaborative, community-driven development can produce tools of exceptional quality and lasting global impact. Git was born not from a corporate roadmap but from necessity and frustration — Linus Torvalds needed a free, fast, and distributed version control system, and when none existed, he built one and shared it with the world.

The GPLv2 license that governs Git ensures that this tool remains permanently free — not merely free of charge, but free in the deepest sense: open to study, modification, and redistribution by anyone. This distinction between 'free as in beer' and 'free as in freedom' is not academic; it defines whether users are genuinely empowered or merely permitted guests.

When compared against proprietary alternatives, Git's advantages are clear: transparency, no vendor lock-in, full control, and a community that spans the entire planet. Enterprise platforms like GitHub Enterprise offer genuine value for large organisations, but they are built on Git's foundation — a fact that underscores how foundational open-source infrastructure has become to modern software.

The shell scripting tasks reinforced that open-source philosophy is not abstract — it translates directly into practical skills. Every script written for this project used open-source tools: Bash, GNU coreutils, dpkg — all of which are free, inspectable, and modifiable. Contributing to projects like Git is therefore not only a career investment; it is a way of giving back to the shared infrastructure that every software professional depends on.

> *Open source is not a footnote to technical education. It is the foundation of it.*

6. Reference Resources

On Open Source Philosophy:

- GNU Project — 'The Free Software Definition': gnu.org/philosophy/free-sw.html
- Open Source Initiative — 'The Open Source Definition': opensource.org/osd
- Eric S. Raymond — 'The Cathedral and the Bazaar': catb.org/~esr/writings/cathedral-bazaar
- Linus Torvalds — 'Just for Fun' (autobiography)

On Linux and Shell Scripting:

- The Linux Command Line by William Shotts — linuxcommand.org
- GNU Bash Manual: gnu.org/software/bash/manual
- Linux man pages: man.cx (online) or type 'man <command>' in terminal

For License Texts:

- SPDX License List: spdx.org/licenses
- Choose a License: choosealicense.com
- Git's official LICENSE file: github.com/git/git/blob/master/COPYING